Leah Christiani

CONTACT INFORMATION

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EMPLOYMENT

Hunter College, CUNY, New York, New York
Associate Professor (pre-tenure), Department of Political Science, 2023 – present

The University of Tennessee, Knoxville, Tennessee
Assistant Professor, Department of Political Science, 2020 – 2023
Faculty Affiliate, Women, Gender, and Sexuality Program, 2020 – 2023
Fellow, Center for the Study of Social Justice, 2022 – 2023

EDUCATION

The University of North Carolina, Chapel Hill, North Carolina
Ph.D., Political Science, 2020
M.A., Political Science, 2017

The University of Connecticut, Storrs, Connecticut
B.A. (*summa cum laude*) with Honors, Political Science, 2011

INTERESTS

American Politics · Race, Ethnicity, and Politics · Political Behavior · Public Opinion · Inequality · Policing · Intersectionality · Gender and Identity

BOOK

Christiani, Leah. 2026. *Destabilized: Why White Americans Accept Racist Political Rhetoric.* Cambridge University Press.

PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES

Christiani, Leah, Nathan J. Kelly, and Jana Morgan. 2026. "Measuring racial attitudes pre-treatment in survey experiments" *Political Science Research and Methods*: 1-8.

Christiani, Leah, Lane Cuthbert, and Kelsey Shoub. 2026. "Examining how narratives of events change attitudes or motivate political participation: The case of police violence." *Journal of Race, Ethnicity, and Politics,* 11(3): 1323–1350.

Shoub, Kelsey, Jamil Scott, and Leah Christiani. 2026. "The racialization of the United States Supreme Court? Examining changes in public opinion toward SCOTUS over time." *Political Behavior,* 48: 613–633.

- Covered by UMass Amherst

Christiani, Leah, and Jeremiah Muhammad. 2025. "Pandering politics? Examining the effect of positive, explicit racial appeals on support for political

candidates." *Du Bois Review,* 22(2): 237–257.

Christiani, Leah, Nathan J. Kelly, and Jana Morgan. 2025. "The structural origins of racial inequality and attitudes toward redistribution." *Race and Social Problems,* 17: 128–139.

Morgan, Jana, Leah Christiani, and Nathan J. Kelly. 2025. "Racial inequality and support for democracy." *Political Studies,* 73(4): 1347–1369.

- Honorable mention, Harrison Prize for the best article published in *Political Studies*, 2025

Laterzo-Tingley, Isabel, and Leah Christiani. 2024. "The 'tough-on-crime' Left: Race, gender, and elections of law and order Democrats." *Research & Politics,* 11(3).

Christiani, Leah, Nathan J. Kelly, and Jana Morgan. 2024. "American dream versus American reality: How encountering information about structural racism can prompt support for race-based policies." *Journal of Race, Ethnicity, and Politics,* 9(2): 399–422.

Williams, Ryan and Leah Christiani. 2024. "Are you talking to me? How ideological and gender characteristics moderate the effect of legitimizing rhetoric on SCOTUS legitimacy." *Law and Social Inquiry,* 49(4): 1939–1963.

Christiani, Leah and Lucy Britt. 2024. "White privilege, white grievance, and the limitations of white antiracism." *Politics, Groups, and Identities,* 12(3): 700–721.

Shoub, Kelsey and Leah Christiani. 2023. "Context matters: The conditional effect of Black police chiefs on policing outcomes." *Urban Affairs Review,* 59(6), 2043–2056.

Christiani, Leah. 2023. "When are explicit racial appeals accepted? Examining the role of racial status threat." *Political Behavior,* 45: 103–123.

- Winner, best graduate student paper 2019 (UNC Political Science)

Christiani, Leah and Kelsey Shoub. 2022. "Can light contact with the police motivate political participation? Evidence from traffic stops." *Journal of Race, Ethnicity, and Politics,* 7(3): 385–405.

Christiani, Leah, Christopher J. Clark, Steven Greene, Marc J. Hetherington, and Emily Wager. 2022. "Masks and racial stereotypes in a pandemic: The case for surgical masks." *Journal of Race, Ethnicity, and Politics,* 7(2): 185–202.

- Covered by WRAL, FiveThirtyEight, ABC11, and The Monkey Cage

Roach, Kevin, Frank R. Baumgartner, Leah Christiani, Derek A. Epp, and Kelsey Shoub. 2022. "At the intersection: Race, gender, and discretion in police traffic stop outcomes." *Journal of Race, Ethnicity, and Politics,* 7(2): 239–261.

Christiani, Leah, Kelsey Shoub, Frank R. Baumgartner, Derek A. Epp, and Kevin Roach. 2022. "Better for everyone: Black descriptive representation and police traffic stops." *Politics, Groups, and Identities,* 10(5): 807–816.

Christiani, Leah. 2021. "Intersectional stereotyping in policing: An analysis of traffic stop outcomes." *Politics, Groups, and Identities*, 9(5): 893–915.

- Anthologized in *The politics of protest: Readings on the Black Lives Matter movement.* Nadia E. Brown, Ray Block Jr., and Christopher Stout, eds. 2021, 1st edition. Routledge.
- Winner, best Master's thesis 2018 (UNC Political Science)

Shoub, Kelsey, Leah Christiani, Frank R. Baumgartner, Derek A. Epp, and Kevin Roach. 2021. "Fines, fees, forfeitures, and disparities: A link between municipal reliance on fines and racial disparities in policing." *Policy Studies Journal*, 49(3): 835–859.

- Reprinted in *Applying Policy Process Research to Policing Subsystems: Looking Back and Moving Forward.* Jack Mewhirter, James E. Wright II, Jill Nicholson-Crotty, and Sean Nicholson-Crotty, eds. 2024.

Shoub, Kelsey, Derek A. Epp, Frank R. Baumgartner, Leah Christiani, and Kevin Roach. 2020. "Race, place, and context: The persistence of race effects in traffic stop outcomes in the face of situational, demographic, and political controls." *Journal of Race, Ethnicity, and Politics*, 5(3): 481–508.

Works in Progress

"Symbolic messages or racialized attitudes? Examining the case of support for Ketanji Brown Jackson" (with Tess Snodgrass, Jamil Scott, and Kelsey Shoub). *Invitation to revise and resubmit.*

"How Latines react to anti-Latine rhetoric" (with Laura Uribe). *Under Review.*

"Examining changes in public opinion toward SCOTUS over time among Black Americans" (with Jamil Scott and Kelsey Shoub). *Invitation to revise and resubmit.*

Reviews

Christiani, Leah. 2023. "The State You See: How Government Visibility Created Political Distrust and Racial Inequality. By Aaron J. Rosenthal. Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 2023. $80.00 hardcover, $34.95 paper, open access online." *Perspectives on Politics.*

Christiani, Leah. 2023. "Neighborhood Watch: Policing White Spaces in Amer-

ica. By Shawn E. Fields. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2022. 193 pp. $29.99 Paper." *Journal of Race, Ethnicity, and Politics.*

Christiani, Leah. 2023. "*Profiled.* Directed by Kathleen Foster. New York: Women Make Movies, 2016. 52 minutes. *Always in Season.* Directed by Jacqueline Olive. Los Angeles: Good Docs, 2019. 89 minutes." *Films for the Feminist Classroom.* 12.1: Summer.

Other Publications

Christiani, Leah. 2026. "Police Gender Bias and Traffic Stops" in Janet P. Stamatel, Ed., *The Sage Encyclopedia of Crime and Gender,* volume 3. SAGE Publications.

Baumgartner, Frank R., Leah Christiani, Derek A. Epp, Kevin Roach, and Kelsey Shoub. 2017. "Racial disparities in traffic stop outcomes." *Duke Forum for Law and Social Change.* 9: 21-53.

- Covered by InjusticeWatch, The Daily Northwestern
- Cited in State of Oregon v. Arreola-Botello, 365 Or 695 (2019)

Public Writing & Reports

"White racial resentment used to undermine support for the Supreme Court. Now it boosts it." (with Kelsey Shoub and Jamil Scott). *London School of Economics (LSE) Blog.* June 2, 2025.

"To generate support for reducing racial inequality among white Americans, the focus should be on structural racism" (with Nathan J. Kelly and Jana Morgan). *London School of Economics (LSE) Blog.* July 5, 2024.

"Time to take off the mask? Some people assumed Black men in masks were threatening, our research found" (with Christopher J. Clark, Steven Greene, Marc Hetherington, and Emily Wager). *The Washington Post (Monkey Cage).* May 28, 2021.

"Ten years of study and the protestors are right: What traffic stops tell us about racial bias in policing" (with Frank R. Baumgartner, Derek A. Epp, Kelsey Shoub, and Kevin Roach). *Medium.* June 25, 2020.

"To fight the coronavirus, most Americans support universal testing and mandatory quarantines" (with Marc Hetherington, Michael MacKuen, Graeme Robertson, and Emily Wager). *The Washington Post (Monkey Cage).* May 15, 2020.

"Update on racial disparities in traffic stops statistics from the Texas Department of Public Safety using 2016 data" (with Frank R. Baumgartner and Kevin Roach). Prepared on April 26, 2017.

"Analyzing racial disparities in traffic stop statistics from the Texas Department of Public Safety" (with Frank R. Baumgartner and Kevin Roach). Prepared

for the September 20, 2016 committee hearing on the Texas Department of Public Safety's traffic statistics.

Invited Presentations

City University of New York (CUNY) Graduate Center. October 2026.

University of Massachusetts, Amherst. October 2025.

Princeton University, Race and Electoral Systems (POL 348). March 2025.

University of North Carolina, APRG 25th Anniversary. September 2023.

East Tennessee State University. April 2022.

University of South Carolina. February 2022.

University of Tennessee, University Housing. October 2020.

University of North Carolina, Intersectionality: Race, Gender, Sexuality, and Social Justice (POLI 248). April 2018.

Grants, Awards, & Scholarships

2025 – Traditional A Research Award, PSC-CUNY
2022 – Racial Justice and Equity Research Fund, University of South Carolina *(Co-PI with Kelsey Shoub)*
2022 – The Centennial Center, APSA *(Co-PI with JAWS Organizers)*
2022 – The Centennial Center, APSA *(Co-PI with Jeremiah Muhammad)*
2021 – Southeastern Conference Visiting Faculty Travel Grant Program
2021 – Faculty mentor, UTK Office of Undergraduate Research
2020 – Departmental nominee, Dean's Distinguished Dissertation Award, UNC
2020 – Faculty R.A. Funding, UTK Office of Undergraduate Research
2019-2020 – Dissertation Completion Fellowship, UNC CAS
2019 – Society for Political Methodology Travel Award
2019 – Best Graduate Student Paper, UNC Political Science
2019 – Uhlman Fellow, UNC Department of Political Science
2018-2019 – Dean's Graduate Fellow, UNC College of Arts and Sciences
2018 – Best Master's Thesis, UNC Political Science
2017 – Graduate Student Transportation Grant Award, UNC
2017 – Ayers Family Travel Award, UNC
2017 – Prestage-Cook Travel Award, SPSA
2012 – Segal Education Award, AmeriCorps
2011 – CLAS Outstanding Woman Scholar, UConn
2011 – Naval Academy Foreign Affairs Conference, UConn representative
2011 – Fannie Dixon Welch Scholarship, UConn
2011 – Babbidge Scholar, UConn

Conference Presentations

American Political Science Association Annual Meeting: '16, '18 – '22, '26

Politics of Race, Immigration, and Ethnicity Consortium (PRIEC): '24
Justice & Injustice Conference: '24
Midwest Political Science Association Annual Meeting: '17 – '19, '22
Southern Political Science Association Annual Meeting: '17, '22
Atlanta Network for the Study of Race, Ethnicity, and Politics (ANREP): '22
APSA Women's Mentoring Workshop: '21
APSA Political Psychology Pre-Conference: '19
Harvard Experimental Political Science Workshop: '19
Society for Political Methodology Annual Meeting: '19
Duke Forum for Law and Social Change: '17

Teaching Experience

Hunter College, CUNY
Instructor
- American Government: A Historical Introduction
- Gender and Politics
- Public Opinion and Political Participation
- Race, Policing, and Criminal Justice

The University of Tennessee
Instructor
- Research Methods
- Gender and Politics
- Public Opinion and Political Socialization (Graduate level)
- Race, Ethnicity, and American Politics

Training
- Safe Zone at UT: Pride Center

The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill
Instructor
- Quantitative Methods in Political Science

Teaching Assistant
- Probability and Statistics (Graduate level)
- Intersectionality: Race, Gender, Sexuality, and Social Justice
- Introduction to American Politics

Graduate Research Consultant
- Political Psychology

Statistical Consultant
- The Odum Institute for Research in Social Science

Grader
- Race, Innocence, & the Decline of the Death Penalty
- Introduction to American Politics

Training
- Mental Health First Aid, Certification

Professional Service and Activity

Discipline
Referee: *American Journal of Political Science (AJPS)*; *American Political Science Review (APSR)*; *American Sociological Review (ASR)*; *American Journal*

of Undergraduate Research; *British Journal of Political Science (BJPS)*; *Canadian Journal of Political Science (CJPS)*; *Cambridge Elements*; *Cultural Diversity and Ethnic Minority Psychology*; *De Gruyter*; *Electoral Studies*; *Environmental Politics*; *Frontiers in Public Health*; *Journal of Politics (JOP)*; *Journal of Elections, Public Opinion, and Parties*; *Journal of Experimental Political Science (JEPS)*; *Journal of Race, Ethnicity, and Politics (JREP)*; *Journal of Women, Politics, and Policy*; *Journal of Public Administration Research and Theory*; *Journal of Policing, Intelligence, and Counter Terrorism*; *Journal of Urban Affairs*; *Perspectives on Politics*; *Policy Studies Journal (PSJ)*; *Political Behavior (PB)*; *Political Research Quarterly (PRQ)*; *Politics, Groups, and Identities (PGI)*; *Politics & Gender*; *Public Administration*; *Polity*; *PS: Political Science & Politics*; *Russell Sage Foundation*; *Social Problems*; *Time-Sharing Experiments for the Social Sciences (TESS)*

Discussant and/or Chair: PRIEC (2024), Justice & Injustice Conference (2024, 2026), MPSA (2022), SPSA (2022), APSA (2020, 2026)

Associate Organizer: Junior Americanist Workshop Series (2021 – 2024)

Member: WPSA's Critical Whiteness Studies Virtual Community (2021 – 2022)

Hunter College, CUNY
Faculty Delegate Assembly, Political Science delegate (2025 – present)
Department of Political Science Policy Committee (Fall 2026 – present)
Department of Political Science Advisor (Fall 2025, Summer 2026, Fall 2026)
Senate Grade Appeals Committee, Hunter College (2024 – present)
Dolciani Math Learning Center Faculty Panel, Hunter College (2023 – present)
Departmental Grade Appeal Committee, Political Science Department (2024)
Faculty Notetaker, Political Science Department (2023 – 2024)

The University of Tennessee
Provost's Junior Faculty Fellows (2022 – 2023)
Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Committee (2020 – 2023)
Advisory Committee (2021 – 2022)
Search Committee, Director of MPPA Program (Spring 2022)
Search Committee, Department Head (Spring 2022)
Search Committee, Assistant Professor (Fall 2021)
Baker's Scholar Advisor: Two UTK undergraduates (2020 – 2022)
Facilitator, Constitution Day Celebration (2020)

The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill
Program Coordinator, State Politics Working Group (2019 – 2020)
Program Coordinator, American Politics Research Group (2017 – 2018)
Search Committee, Assistant Professor in Political Methodology (2018)
Member, GIS Working Group (2016 – 2018)
Member, Chapel Hill Area Media Project (2015 – 2020)

Research Experience & Advising

Honors Thesis Advisor: 7 Hunter undergraduates (2023 – present)
Advisor, Mellon Public Humanities and Social Justice (2024 – 2025; 2026 – 2027)
Advisor, Baker's Scholar: 2 UTK undergraduates (2020 – 2022)

Supervisor: 6 UTK undergraduates (2020 – 2021)
Supervisor: 13 UNC undergraduates (2019 – 2020)
Research Assistant: Marc Hetherington (2020)
Research Assistant: Frank R. Baumgartner (2015 – 2020)